taqid (imitation). There had been indications much earlier in Akbar's reign that showed the Padshah questioning long-accepted suppositions. Whether it was testing the theory of a 'natural language' through the isolation of infants or questioning the need for circumcision—'it is a remarkable thing that men should insist on the ceremony of circumcision for children' said Akbar, 'who are otherwise excused from the burden of all religious obligations'—the Padshah would now put to the test and interrogate all claims that appeared dubious.

As he reconciled these many troubling ideas into a structure with which to rule a diverse country, justly and well, Akbar took the ideas of Ibn Arabi to draw a conclusion that was abhorrent to the orthodox, whether Muslims, like Badauni, or Christians, like the Jesuits. Akbar proposed that 'all religions are either equally true or equally illusory'. In addition to his personal search for a greater truth, Akbar wanted to develop and implement, as pointed out by Irfan Habib, 'an accepted code of ethical and legal behaviour', that not only made him a better person but also a greater king to all the subjects in his land. This would make the Hindustan of the late sixteenth century a place unique in the Muslim world and, indeed, in the world at large.

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*Zinc.

†Medicines, which were expensive and rare.